Kanban in a Nutshell

Second of three short pieces on ways of working, following Scrum and leading into flow.
Kanban is the method I reach for most, partly because it starts without a fight.

Start Where You Are

Kanban's opening move is unique among methods: change nothing. No new roles, no reorganisation, no ceremony calendar. Take the process you already have, make every piece of work in it visible on a board, and agree as a group what the columns and rules actually are. Most teams discover in the first hour that they hold wildly different beliefs about how their own work works, and that discovery is worth more than any framework rollout I have ever seen.

The Board Is Not the Method

Plenty of teams have a board and none of the benefit, because the board is just a window. The method is what you do through it: limit work in progress, pull work rather than accept pushes, and make your policies explicit enough that a newcomer could follow them. The WIP limit is the part everyone resists and the part that does the work. When a column is full, the correct response is to finish something, help someone or improve the system, and never to start something new. Stop starting, start finishing is the entire philosophy in four words.

Manage the Flow, Not the People

Once work is visible and limited, the interesting questions change. How long do items actually take, door to door? Where do they wait, and for whom? How old is the oldest thing on the board, and why is nobody worried about it? Blocked items get flagged and aged in public. The invisible workload, the support, the favours, the incidents, goes on the board too, because a board that hides half the work is a fiction with columns. None of this requires estimating anything.

Improve at a Cadence

Kanban reviews the system, not the people. A short regular look at the flow data, one policy changed at a time, and the humility to treat every change as an experiment that might be

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reversed. It is hypothesis-driven working applied to your own process, which is why it compounds: teams that run it for a year are unrecognisable, and nobody can point to the day anything dramatic happened.

Where It Goes Wrong

A board with no work-in-progress limits is a status display rather than a method. Columns that map to job titles quietly rebuild the silos the board was meant to dissolve. And a board nobody replans from becomes an archaeology exhibit, updated the hour before the review. The tell in every case is the same: the board describes the work, but no longer changes it.

> **How I use it:** everywhere, including with leadership teams, whose portfolios benefit from WIP limits even more than delivery teams do. The working version is on the site as the Flow Health Check template: run it against your own board and see where work actually waits. And when the numbers need reading, the next piece, flow in a nutshell, is the physics. Running this with a leadership team in the room is a thing I do.

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